



PHOTOGRAPH: Mexy Xavier

Get Office XP's voice recognition working for you and give your hands that much needed break

Stop typing and start talking to your computer. That's the promise of voice recognition. The latest advancements in voice recognition software makes 'digital dictation' a reality. No more typing long letters and filling in humongous data sheets!

IBM's Via Voice, Philips Free Speech, and Dragon's Naturally Speaking are some of the software currently available in the market. Now even Office XP comes integrated with voice recognition capabilities. In this workshop, we guide you through the process of installing and working with the voice technology integrated in Microsoft's Office XP.

Installation

Voice recognition is not installed by default with Office XP. You will need to run set up from the Office XP CD. To install the feature, select 'Customize installation'. Now choose the programs that you want to install, i.e. Word, Access or Outlook. At the bottom, select 'Choose detailed installations of each application'. Click 'Next'. You'll now see a screen from where you can select the features you want

to install with each application. Here, navigate to the 'Office Shared Features' folder. You will find the option 'Alternative User Input' under which you will have further options of 'Speech' and 'Handwriting'. Click on them and select 'Run all from my



Installing the voice recognition feature

computer'. Follow the onscreen procedure to finish the installation.

Training the software

Voice recognition will only operate correctly if you train it, and you might have to invest considerable time with it to

increase the accuracy level. Before going ahead with the training program make sure you are in a quiet environment. Background noises make it difficult for the software to interpret words and you will have to speak louder. Remember to speak slowly and clearly and not to rush through the sample sentences, as the software may not be able to recognise all the words at the first go. Also, before proceeding with the training, remember to tweak the microphone sensitivity level. Double-click on the volume control icon in the system tray. From the 'Options' menu choose 'Properties'. Now select the 'Recording' radio button and click 'OK'. You can adjust the microphone level with the 'Microphone Balance' slider.

The first time you train the software, you will be asked to fill in details such as your age and gender. Next, you will have to speak into the microphone to test it. After this you will have to go through a training program wherein you will be prompted to read sample sentences. When you're done, click on the 'Finish' button to complete the training program. This is the basic training session. If you